

## Chapter - 1

# The Glory of Braj - The Divine Land of Mathura-Vrindavan

*The tale of an eternal abode - where love was about to descend*

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*By Maa's grace the servant - Maa's own work - Maa's own glory.*

### Invocation

वृन्दारण्यं परं धाम यत्र राधा च माधवः।  
नित्यं क्रीडा कुर्वन्तौ तत्र मे सन्तु दृष्टयः॥

**Meaning** - Vrindavan is that supreme abode where Radha and Madhava eternally sport in divine play - may my eyes ever behold that abode.

### Goloka - where even time stands still

Beyond this material universe, beyond even the boundaries of time and space, there exists an abode which the scriptures call Goloka. There, there is no birth, no death - there only one truth eternally abides, and that truth is love. In that abode flows a divine river named Yamuna, the kadamba trees there are forever in bloom, and the strain of a flute never falls silent.

At the very heart of that Goloka lies a rasa-grove, where the Supreme Being Himself - in the supreme form of madhurya (sweetness) - eternally dwells with the Mistress of His heart. Where Vaikuntha is governed by aishwarya (majestic opulence) and a mood of reverence, in Goloka there is but one mood - an unparalleled love brimming with sakhya (friendship), vatsalya (parental affection), and madhurya. It is for this reason that the devotional tradition holds Goloka to be even more profound and more sweet than Vaikuntha.

It is said that in Goloka even time flows to a different rhythm - there is neither past nor future there, only an eternal present, in which love remains ever fresh, never growing old. The kadamba groves there, the gopis there, the cows there - all of it is fashioned from that same one truth, which devotees call love and the wise call the Supreme Brahman. This abode is not attained through austerity, but is revealed only through unconditional grace.

### The dialogue between Sage Narada and Lord Brahma

Once, in the early ages of creation, the divine sage Narada came before Lord Brahma. A question had long been stirring in his mind - a question whose answer was not entirely clear even to himself. Carrying his veena upon his shoulder, Narada entered that golden courtyard of Satyaloka, where Brahma sat in meditation beside his swan-vehicle.

#### Narada and Brahma - on the mystery of Goloka

**Narada (humbly, with folded hands)** - Grandfather, I have beheld Vaikuntha, I have beheld Lord Vishnu Himself reclining upon Sheshanaga in the Ocean of Milk. But this Goloka of which I hear spoken of - what manner of abode is it? Why does it differ from Vaikuntha?

**Brahma (smiling with affection)** - Dear child Narada, Vaikuntha is the abode of aishwarya - there, the mood of reverence between devotee and Lord prevails. But Goloka - Goloka is the abode of madhurya. There, the Lord conceals His majesty entirely, and presents Himself as a simple cowherd boy, so that His beloved ones may bind themselves to Him without any hesitation, without any fear, in pure love alone.

**Narada (leaning forward with eagerness)** - Then does that abode too have a Mistress of the Lord's heart, as Vaikuntha has Lakshmi?

**Brahma (growing solemn)** - Dear child, the Mistress of the heart who dwells there is beyond even Lakshmi. She is the Lord's own hladini shakti (the joy-giving power) - that power from which love itself arises, without which even the Lord's form of sweetness remains incomplete. Her name is Radha.

**Narada (astonished)** - Radha! How sweet even this name is, Grandfather. Will this power remain forever in Goloka, or will it ever descend upon the earth as well?

**Brahma (gazing into the distance with far-seeing eyes)** - Know this too, Narada - whenever the earth needs to be taught what true love is, then this very Goloka will descend upon the earth in a small form. And that time is no longer far off, dear child. Upon the banks of the Yamuna, in the land of the Mathura region, that divine play which has been awaited for ages upon ages is soon to begin.

**Narada (bowing his head in reverence)** - Blessed is that land, Grandfather, which shall bear witness to this play. I too shall wait in anticipation of that vision, and when that moment comes, I shall sing of that very love upon my veena.

**Brahma (bestowing his blessing)** - So shall it be, dear child. Go now, and hold this mystery within your heart, until time itself chooses to reveal it.

### **The distinction between Vaikuntha and Goloka**

In Vaikuntha, the mood of aishwarya toward the Lord Himself prevails - there the devotee knows that the one he serves is the Master of the entire universe, and this knowledge maintains a natural distance and reverence within his love.

In Goloka, by contrast, the mood of madhurya prevails - there the Lord Himself conceals His majesty and dwells as an ordinary cowherd boy, so that his companions may play with him shoulder to shoulder, his mother may scold him, and his beloved may even quarrel with him in sulking. This is the very pinnacle of madhurya - where love becomes so dense that majesty itself becomes secondary before it.

### **A description of Goloka**

**गोलोकं परमं धाम प्रेमानन्दैकसिन्धुना।  
राधामाधवयोर्नित्यं रासलीलाविलासितम्॥**

**Meaning** - Goloka is that supreme abode filled with the boundless ocean of the bliss of love, where the rasa-lila of Radha and Madhava eternally unfolds.

### **Mathura-Vrindavan - heaven descended upon earth**

That land settled upon the banks of the Yamuna, which the world knows by the name of Mathura-Vrindavan, is no ordinary land. In the devotional tradition it is regarded as the very earthly reflection of Goloka, just as a reflection in a mirror is itself an image of the real object, and yet remains connected to it. Every grain of soil here, every tree here, even the very air that flows here - all of it seemed to be holding its breath in wait for some divine play.

Mathura - once the capital of the Shurasena kingdom, situated on the western bank of the Yamuna - was destined to become witness to an event that would change the history of all creation. And Vrindavan - that forest region across the Yamuna, where tulsi and kadamba trees grew naturally - was to become the very heart of that divine play.

Around this land spread twelve forests - Madhuvan, Talvan, Kumudvan, Bahulavan, Kamyavan, Khadiravan, Bhadravan, Bhandiravan, Mahavan, Lohavan, Bilvavan, and Vrindavan. Each forest held within itself a distinct mystery, and each forest was destined to become witness to some divine play in the time to come. Madhuvan carried the sweetness of honey, Kamyavan held the boon of fulfilled desires, and Bilvavan held within it the memory of Lord Shiva's penance.

Through the midst of these forests ran little footpaths, along which the gopas and gopis came and went each day with their cows. It was upon these very footpaths that, in time to come, those footprints would be imprinted which would be worshipped for ages upon ages. But for now, this land was merely a tranquil, verdant forest expanse, whose own destiny was not yet fully known even to itself.

### **Yamuna - not merely a river**

To regard the Yamuna as merely a geographical river is to understand only half the mystery of this land. In devotional literature, the Yamuna is described as the Daughter of the Sun and as Kalindi herself - a living, conscious being, who was to become the silent witness of all the divine plays yet to come. It is said that the Yamuna herself knew that her banks would soon witness a love whose echo would resound for ages upon ages, and it was in this very anticipation that a special restlessness and sweetness had settled into her current.

The waters of the Yamuna too are held to be different from other rivers, carrying a faint dark hue - as though she had already taken into herself the color of her coming Shyamsundar. Every single thing of this land, be it water, tree, or air - all of it seemed eager to be dyed in that one same color, in anticipation of that divine play.

### **The prophecy of Sage Garga**

In this very period another event took place, of which very few people had knowledge. The great sage Garga, who was the family preceptor of the Yadu dynasty, was once absorbed in penance, when a divine vision came upon him. He saw that upon both banks of the Yamuna, on one side in Barsana and on the other in Gokul, two divine lights were about to descend, who would be bound to each other so deeply that separating them would be impossible.

Sage Garga did not record this vision in any diary, but held it instead within his own heart, knowing that this mystery would reveal itself in its own time. He spoke only this much in the form of prophecy - that in the time to come, this land would become so sacred that the mere touch of its dust would prove more fruitful than the penance of even the greatest ascetics. This word was, in time, to be proven true to the very letter.

### **The spiritual mystery of the twelve forests**

It is held in the devotional tradition that these twelve forests of Braj were not mere clusters of vegetation, but that each forest held within itself a particular rasa, a particular mood. In Talvan, where the tall palm trees seemed to touch the sky, there was a grave, ascetic-like atmosphere. In Khadiravan, amid the density of the khair trees, dwelt a mysterious, hidden peace.

Bhandiravan, which was to prove exceedingly significant in time to come, was renowned for its vast banyan trees - the shade of these trees was so dense that even beneath the fierce noonday sun, a cool, dusk-like atmosphere prevailed there. Mahavan, which lay very close to Gokul, was known for its fertility - the soil here was so rich that fruits and flowers grew in abundance even without any special effort.

Among all these forests, Vrindavan held the foremost place, for here tulsi plants grew naturally, without any planting, entirely of their own accord. This was that very tulsi which was, in time to come, to be worshipped throughout all of India as a symbol of devotion. This land seemed to already know what manner of devotion and what manner of love was to descend here, and so it had adorned each of its trees, each of its herbs, in keeping with that very purpose.

### **Vrishabhanu's yajna-sadhana**

Once, desiring the blessing of a child, Vrishabhanu duly arranged a yajna, to which sages and ascetics were invited from far and wide. As the offerings were being poured into the sacrificial fire, one elderly ascetic among the assembled priests spoke in a most solemn voice, saying that the fruit of this yajna would be far greater than the mere blessing of a child - this fruit would prove auspicious for the welfare of all three worlds.

Vrishabhanu accepted this prophecy with humility, though its full meaning was not clear even to him in that moment. At the conclusion of the yajna, as all the guests were taking their leave, a gentle shower of flowers fell from the sky, which many of those present witnessed and were astonished by. This event too was a part of that very chain of happenings that was soon to reach its fulfillment.

### **The sanctity of waiting**

It is taught in the devotional tradition that the waiting done with faith and patience never goes in vain. This long waiting of Vrishabhanu and Kirtida was filled not with despair or complaint, but with unceasing penance and trust - this is why their waiting was, in the end, to prove a boon for the whole of creation.

It is also worth remembering that divine plans always reveal themselves beyond human understanding, in their own time. Whoever accepts this waiting patiently, without any complaint, alone becomes, in the end, the true recipient of that divine grace.

### **A tranquil evening - the land in waiting**

In those days there was a wondrous stillness in Vrindavan, yet within that stillness too a stirring lay hidden - as though nature herself was holding her breath before some great event was about to occur. The cows, while grazing, would turn of their own accord to face the Yamuna and stand still, as though awaiting someone. Peacocks began to dance without any rain falling. The kadamba trees had begun to put forth buds before their season.

At the hour of evening, as the sun moved toward the western horizon, the sky would fill with a strange golden-rose glow, as though nature herself were scattering colors in preparation for some festival. The leaves of the trees would stir even without any wind, and a particular rhythm would arise in the waves of the Yamuna, resembling some unstruck, unheard melody. The birds of the forest too had brought a new sweetness into their song, as though they too were singing a song of welcome for some arrival.

Near Vrindavan, upon a small hill named Barsana, dwelt a renowned gopa-chieftain named Vrishabhanu. He was the master of ten hundred thousand cows, was devoted to dharma, and his wife Kirtida was equally virtuous. Yet in their life there was one single incompleteness - though years had passed, they had no child. This incompleteness had settled in their hearts as a quiet, abiding emptiness, which they had never been able to fill, not with all their wealth, nor with the affection of their people.

And it was this very incompleteness which, without their knowing it, was to become the first door to that divine play which was now soon to begin. Every day, as Vrishabhanu performed his evening worship on the banks of the Yamuna, he would offer this prayer - that if the joy of a child was written in his fate, may the Goddess grant him that joy soon, and if it was not so written, then he would remain content even so. It was this very desireless spirit that was the greatest strength of his penance.

### **Kirtida's penance and the call of her innermost heart**

Kirtida too was as patient as her husband, yet the tender restlessness that belongs to a woman's heart dwelt within her as well. Every day, after her morning bath in the Yamuna, she would worship the Goddess Bhagavati, offer water to the tulsi in her courtyard, and repeat within her mind the faith that by the grace of the Mother of the universe, all would surely be well.

One night, Kirtida had a most strange dream - she saw that from the waters of the Yamuna an otherworldly light was rising, and from within that light a sweet, tender voice was calling to her, "Mother, I am coming." She awoke from the dream with her heart pounding rapidly, and tears of joy in her eyes, though she did not fully know the meaning of this dream.

She told Vrishabhanu of this dream, and both of them, taking it as an auspicious sign, held it close within their hearts. After that night, a strange peace settled over Kirtida's mind, as though her own heart knew that the waiting was now drawing to its end. She would often sit for hours on the banks of the Yamuna, gazing at the waves of the water, as though awaiting some divine sign.

### **Vrishabhanu and Kirtida - counsel over the dream**

**Kirtida (in a voice restless yet filled with hope)** - My lord, last night I saw a wondrous dream. A light rose from the waters of the Yamuna, and from within it someone called me "Mother." What sign is this? I cannot understand it.

**Vrishabhanu (gravely, then smiling)** - Beloved, the yajna we performed, the penance through which we have waited these many years, surely points toward some auspicious fruit. This dream too seems to me a divine assurance.

**Kirtida (with hope in her eyes)** - Then is our waiting now about to end, my lord?

**Vrishabhanu (with calm resolve)** - That only time will tell, beloved. But this much is certain - the Goddess who is our protector never disappoints her devotees. We need only wait with faith and patience.

### **The message of the land of Braj**

*Where a land waits in expectation of love, there even time stands still - and that waiting is never in vain*



And upon that very land held in waiting, upon the banks of the Yamuna, a dawn was soon to break that would change all of Braj forever. That incompleteness of Vrishabhanu was now about to turn into fulfillment - and with that fulfillment was to descend she whom the world would remember, for ages to come, as the purest definition of love.

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### **Summary**

This chapter first describes the abode of Goloka - that eternal, divine realm where Radha and Madhava eternally perform the rasa-lila. Through the extended dialogue between the sage Narada and Lord Brahma, the distinction between the aishwarya-mood of Vaikuntha and the madhurya-mood of Goloka is made clear, and it is indicated that this abode of Goloka will descend upon the earth in the form of Mathura-Vrindavan. Thereafter follows a description of the geographical and spiritual glory of Mathura-Vrindavan, mention of the twelve forests, the prophecy of Sage Garga, and a description of the divine nature of the river Yamuna. Finally, the childless life of Vrishabhanu and Kirtida, their penance, and Kirtida's auspicious dream are recounted, indicating that a divine fulfillment is soon to descend upon this land.

Thus ends Khand 1 - The Beginning of Braj

Chapter One - Complete

### **The Servant's Perspective**

*This distinction between Goloka and Vaikuntha compelled me to think deeply - in which, aishwarya or madhurya, does true love reveal itself more fully? It seems to me that the Adishakti Bhagavati Maa Ambe too desires the very same thing from her devotees - that we should not merely worship her from a distance, but form with her the same intimate bond that a child forms with its mother, without any fear or distance. That silent waiting of the Yamuna, that land which, without knowing it, was preparing itself for a great event, that dream of Kirtida in which an unknown voice called her "Mother" - all of this reminds me that no waiting in life ever goes in vain, that Mother surely bestows her grace in her own time. I too have experienced this in my own life - years of waiting, years of struggle, and then fulfillment through Mother's grace. In writing this chapter I feel myself standing on that very land of Vrindavan, waiting, filled with faith. - Suraj Kumar Lohani · An offering to Adishakti Bhagavati Maa Ambe. ॐ नमो श्री भगवती जगदम्बिके दुर्गायै नमः॥*

Shri Adishakti Mahakosh

Khand 1 - The Beginning of Braj